



20 weeks By this stage of gestation, lanugo can be seen on the skin, and the face appears completely human, with fully developed eyebrows, eyelids, lips, ears, fingers, and toes.

made up of the three layers of skin we all have—the epidermis, which is the top layer, the dermis in the middle, and the hypodermis, the deepest layer. The skin doesn't become more “solid” looking or lose any of its permeability until you are 32 weeks pregnant. This is also when the babies' skin complexion starts to take on its pigmentation.

Lanugo is fine, soft, downy hair. It's the first hair to be produced by the fetal hair follicles, and it usually appears on the fetus at about 20 weeks of gestation. It is normally shed before birth, at around 28 or 32 weeks of pregnancy, but is sometimes still present at birth. It disappears within a few days or weeks of the birth. Lanugo keeps *vernix caseosa* (a white, greasy substance) in place on your baby's skin. Vernix starts to appear at around 20 weeks and by 32 weeks it covers most of your baby's body. It's made up of skin cells, fetal skin oil, and lanugo. The Latin term *vernix caseosa* translates as “cheesy varnish.” Vernix helps to keep your baby's skin moist and protect it from exposure to amniotic fluid, which contains high levels of fetal urine (especially toward the end of your pregnancy). It is sometimes still present at birth and can act as a thick, slippery lubricator to encourage your baby's passage down the birth canal during labor.

Q Can my baby smell what's going on inside my uterus?

No one is sure. By 15 weeks pregnant, your fetus has all she needs for her sense of smell to work, but as aromas are passed through the air rather than through fluid, it's always been assumed that her sense of smell doesn't become functional until she's born and starts to breathe air. However, some research has thrown this in doubt and it's now proposed that because your baby is instantly attracted to the smell of your breast milk, she was exposed to the smell of something similar—and therefore familiar—while she was in your uterus.

Q Do my baby's eyes stay closed the whole time she's inside me?

No. Somewhere between 26 and 28 weeks pregnant, she'll close her eyelids in response to bright light and will start to blink. By this stage, her retinas are fully formed, so any risk of damage from bright light has passed. Not only that, but her eyebrows and eyelashes have formed, and they offer extra protection.

Q Can my baby cry tears when she is in the uterus?

Your baby has tear ducts—lacrimal glands—by the end of the first trimester. These are to ensure that her eyeballs are properly moistened throughout gestation, but whether or not they can create tears is still a mystery. Researchers believe that a fetus goes through the motions of crying (distress, frowning, and so on) in response to loud noises, but that's all we know.



Did you know...

» At 7½ weeks pregnant your baby has already developed her first sense—the sense of touch.

» At 18 weeks pregnant she has the ridges in her fingertips that will make her unique fingerprint.

» At 23 weeks pregnant she's covered in a soft, fine, downy hair called lanugo: this will probably almost entirely disappear by the time she's born.